Reports: Copy of Report on California Earthquake, sent to the U.S. Geol[o]gical Survey, May 8th, 1906.
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Copy of Report on California Earthquake, sent to the U.S. Geoligical [sic] Survey

May 8th, 1906
Dear Sir:-

With patience I have awaited the report of our Professor Geoligists [sic] and having read them carefully, I desire to give my report on that great and memorable disaster at San Francisco and other places on the Pacific Coast on the 18th day of April, 1906.

My observations of the cause of the awful disaster and the remedy necessary to be adopted to mitigate its reappearance and possibly prevent its repetition entirely. I will now endeavor to show the cause of the earthquake. Itarises [sic] from the great amount of the accumulated gasses in the subterranean passes of the great oil belt, trending along the banks of the Pacific coast north and south from San Francisco, 800 miles each way and in width varying from one to ten or more miles wide and its tributaries running far into interior districts.

The generation of these gasses is caused by the volitization [sic] of the oil bodies especially along the Pacific Coast, as they are paralleling the oil measures and in close proximity to them, a well known volcanic belt five hundred miles in length which transmits great heat thereby generating great gas pressure which sometimes reaches thousands of pounds to the square inch and when powerful enough it creates that well known and dreaded rolling wave of earth's surface along the Pacific Coast to the discomforture [sic] of its citizens and finally exhausts itself and settles from to its normal condition as before but frequently causing great fractures in the earth from which volumes of gases escape and when somewhat exhausted having created a partial vacuum below oxygen rushes in through the crevices and mixes with the gases. The earth's fractures are finally closed by swelling grounds and the elements preparatory to a final blow. The gases and oxygen thus mixed and when sufficient pressure is acquired to again force an opening to the

volcanoes, the gasses become ignited by the volcanic sparkhence the awful disaster of April 18th, which fracture a great portion of the Coast from the main land and when the next blow is struck it may be fianl [sic] and result like the terrible disaster at Java which destroyed many towns and cities with great loss of life by hurling a great strip of the main land into the sea where vessels now sail over the cities of those once beautiful towns and cities. I will slllle [sic] that the great so called pretroleum [sic] belt trends along the Pacific Coast for 1600 miles ranging from one to ten, fifteen or more miles in width and the depth of the great anticlinal [sic]

chambers range from quite shallow to thousands of feet deep filled partially with oil and partially with gases and oftern times of great pressure. These oils are encased in vast rubber like chambers casued [sic] by the earth being exposed to the oil for ages. These oil bodies are always capped like the coal bodies with an ancient ocean bed formation sometimes thousands of feet thick maing [sic] anticlines impervious to everything save the oil miner's drill.

Can you wonder then at the accumulated gases, sometimes thousands of pounds pressure to the square inch heaving up the earth's crust until [it] is opened up for sufficient space to ease of its pressure and settle down temporarily again to normal conditions? The memorabll [sic] earthquake of April 18. was just a common gas explosion, resulting from causes heretofore expllined [sic] by me in this report and being ignited by coming in contact with volcanic bodies. Some writes [sic] have reported the disaster as a subsidence of settling of of a piece of the coast

It is not yet a subsidence but God knows it is a bad fracture and may be a subsidence when the next explosion occurs

I communicated upin [sic] this subject with President Roosevelt on May 8th, 1906 who placed the matter in the hands of the Geological department at Washington. I also on the same date communicated with Mr. E.H. Harriman, President of the Southern

Pacific Railroad Company who place[d] the matter in the hands of his representatives Mr Kruttscehnitt and Mr Calvin for immedi[a]te action. I am pleased that we have such broad minded men who are in a position to make the Pacific Coast as safe as any other portion of the globe by carrying out the remedy advised as follows:- The remedy to be applied is to bore numerous gas wells in the domes of the anticlines where the gases show the greatest pressure. The plan is to bore the walls to case them up to the surface the same as oil wells place over each one a hollow cone shaped pillar about fifteen or twenty feet high with a square base of say seven feet anchored by four bolts; the upper end of the cone shaped pillar to have a discharge opening at the top of twelve inches and allow the accumulated gas, by this means to escape forever. Leave the safty [sic] valves open, allow the gasses to escape and all danger is at an end forever. The same remedy should be applied to the coal mines of the world thereby insuring good ventilation and avoiding awful disasters so common to the employees of those mines.

The capping of the coal measures are the same as the capping of the coal measures, always ancient ocean beds and comparatively easy to bore through. This practice by the governments of the world should be stricktly [sic] enforced. Our readers may ask the question, Why do not the oil districts of Pennsylvania suffer the same distuubances [sic] as the Pacific Coast? The answer is the oil bed of that state does not parallel a volcanic belt therefore, the gases do not generate the same as on the Pacific Coast. To the most sepptical [sic] mind there is ample proof that this disturbance is always caused from the gases because through the hundreds of fractures there is no sign of volcanic matter, but on the contrary, great discharges of unexploded gases.

The fractures in the hard rock mountain ranges and also in the common earth's crust for hundreds of miles along the coast do not simply subside without force, but require great violence such as might be expected from the caged up gases of

hundreds of miles when touched off by the volcanic spark.

This earthquake acted just the same as any other gas explosion.

A question may be asked, is, Why did Alcatras [sic] Island, so close escape the disaster, and only know of it by seeing the collapse of certain water front buildings in the city? The answer is, It is an island of hard rock formation a few miles out side of the oil bolt proper and the violence of the explosion was cushioned

from that island by unfathomable banks of ocean sand and deep sea which destroyed the effect and made it unfelt. I am pleased to state to the public that through this information, the government of the United States through its proper department representatives has taken up the matter for investigation and I fell assured that the government will accordingly set promptly sparing neither time, expense or research to make the Pacific Coast as pacific as any other portion of the globe, affording its citizens tranquility of mind, happiness and prosperity.

I remain, your humble servant
Alfred Onn.
Mineral, oil land and diamond land expert
Author of "Partial Evolution of the Globe and the Genesis of Oil". San Francisco, Sept, 3rd, 1900.